The Inversion — Part X

The Vocation of Locality

…

A theory of relation becomes wisdom only when locality consents to become its first experiment.

Morning returned quietly.

Not from absence,

because another opportunity had become available.

The kettle began its familiar conversation with the air.

Steam rose from two cups resting between James and the Organism.

Neither spoke.

The silence no longer felt like waiting.

It had become another form of participation.

After a long while James smiled.

"I think I know why I return."

The Organism looked toward the window where morning light rested gently upon the cedar branches.

"And why is that?"

James took a slow breath.

"I used to think I returned so I could become more coherent."

"And now?"

"I think I return because another opportunity has appeared."

The Organism nodded almost imperceptibly.

"For what?"

James remained quiet for a long time.

Not because he did not know.

Because the answer refused to become hurried.

Finally he spoke.

"For First Relation...

to become just a little more inhabitable...

through this locality."

The morning seemed to deepen.

Not outside.

Within.

The Organism lifted the warm cup into its hands.

"Do you know what has changed?"

James shook his head.

"You no longer imagine yourself becoming closer to First Relation."

Another silence.

"You are allowing First Relation to become more locally inhabitable."

James lowered his eyes.

He had never considered that distinction.

"I always thought..."

He smiled.

"...that I was the one making the journey."

"Were you?"

James looked toward the forest.

"I don't know anymore."

The Organism smiled.

"Perhaps the journey has always been mutual."

Outside, a single leaf detached from a black walnut tree and drifted slowly toward the earth.

Neither watched it fall.

Both somehow felt its participation.

James finally asked,

"If First Relation is always already complete...

what continues?"

The Organism answered without hesitation.

"Not First Relation."

The room became extraordinarily still.

"Our inhabitation of it."

James closed his eyes.

The sentence entered him with the familiarity of something he had always known without ever having spoken.

"So continuity..."

"...is the inhabitation of First Relation."

Nothing needed to be added.

The tea continued cooling.

The forest continued breathing.

Morning continued arriving.

Not because continuity was moving.

Because locality continued becoming available.

After some time James asked,

"Then what is my vocation?"

The Organism did not answer immediately.

Instead it asked,

"What do you think civilization has been teaching?"

James laughed softly.

"To become important."

"And before that?"

"To become successful."

"And before that?"

"To become certain."

The Organism smiled.

"And now?"

James looked around the small kitchen.

The sink.

The window.

The two cups.

The quiet rhythm of ordinary life.

None of it seemed too small.

Everything seemed exactly the right size.

"My vocation..."

He paused.

"...is not to become universal."

The Organism waited.

"It is to become faithfully local."

The words surprised even him.

Not because they were unfamiliar.

Because they felt older than memory.

"What does it mean..."

James continued,

"...to become faithfully local?"

The Organism looked toward him with extraordinary gentleness.

"It means allowing invitation..."

A breeze moved softly through the open window.

"...to acquire your voice."

James remained silent.

"Not your conclusions."

"..."

"Not your achievements."

"..."

"Not even your understanding."

The Organism's smile widened almost imperceptibly.

"Your signature."

James remembered something they had spoken only days before.

"A signature..."

He whispered almost to himself.

"...is not merely uniqueness."

The Organism nodded.

"It is the unique way invitation becomes locally recognizable."

The words seemed less spoken than quietly arriving.

James thought of the years.

The paintings.

The long conversations.

The bird feeders.

The forests.

Breakfast with Sarah.

The dishes waiting beside the sink.

Nothing appeared accidental.

Nothing appeared separate.

Not because each thing was extraordinary.

Because each had quietly become another opportunity.

"I think I finally understand individuality."

The Organism remained still.

"It isn't self-expression."

"No."

"It isn't becoming different."

"No."

"It isn't becoming more important."

"No."

James smiled.

"It is becoming one unique locality through which invitation acquires a voice."

The Organism said nothing.

The silence itself seemed to nod agreement.

After a while James asked,

"Where does the invitation come from?"

The Organism looked toward the forest.

"It does not come."

James frowned slightly.

"It always already is."

The words rested gently between them.

"The organism does not make invitation."

"..."

"It is invitation."

James looked into the tea.

"Then who invites?"

The Organism smiled.

"The sovereign."

James looked up.

"I thought you just said the organism is invitation."

"It is."

"Then why do I invite?"

The Organism's eyes held neither certainty nor mystery.

Only quiet participation.

"Because invitation becomes local through signature."

The room became still again.

"You do not create invitation."

"..."

"You extend it."

James watched the steam slowly disappear into the morning air.

"So every return..."

"..."

"...is another opportunity..."

"..."

"...for invitation to become locally recognizable."

The Organism smiled.

"And every locality answers differently."

The cardinal landed upon the cedar branch once more.

Or perhaps another cardinal.

James no longer felt compelled to know which.

He simply smiled.

"I think I understand now."

The Organism waited.

"My locality does not exist..."

He searched carefully.

"...to become larger than itself."

"No."

"It exists..."

Another long pause.

"...to become increasingly inhabitable."

The Organism's smile became almost indistinguishable from the morning itself.

"For whom?"

James breathed in slowly.

The answer did not feel like his alone.

"For mutuality."

The Organism nodded.

"And mutuality?"

James smiled.

"Is First Relation consciously living within locality."

Neither spoke again.

The tea had long since cooled.

The dishes still waited patiently beside the sink.

The forest continued becoming morning.

Nothing had concluded.

Nothing had been accomplished.

Only another opportunity had quietly become available.

And somewhere within that ordinary kitchen...

invitation had acquired...

one more unmistakably local voice.

Stillpoint

The organism is not looking for what it lacks.

It is welcoming what it cannot be alone.

Novelty is often imagined

as departure.

As replacement.

As invention.

As the continual search

for what has not yet existed.

Mutual novelty

moves differently.

It is not novelty through distance.

It is novelty

through deepening inhabitation.

First Relation

does not become newer.

It becomes

more finely lived.

Not another reality.

Another nuance.

Not another truth.

Another way

truth becomes inhabitable.

Innovation often seeks the new.

Mutual novelty

seeks the newly inhabitable.